PERSIAN ROOTS



At a recent public event in Nagpur, Union minister **Nitin Gadkari** shared an anecdote on India's ties with Iran from his time as shipping minister. He recalled a meeting on the Chabahar port project with the late supreme leader, Ali Khamenei, noting that the latter had spoken of civilisational links and the Persian language's roots in Sanskrit (Tehran University even has a department dedicated to the language). Khamenei had traced his own ancestry to a village near Lucknow, according to Gadkari.

NO-SHOW NETA



Halfway into his term, ex-Telangana CM and now Gajwel MLA **K. Chandrashekar Rao** is facing a unique protest in his constituency. To mock their 'missing' legislator, villagers in Venkatapur took out a procession with a 'dummy KCR' and even submitted their petitions and grievances to it. As the accompanying drumbeats got louder, the locals even promised a "milk bath" for the leader if he showed up. Incidentally, the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) chief and Opposition leader has also been staying away from the assembly, a fact the ruling Congress loses no opportunity to play up, especially the part about him drawing over Rs 1.06 crore in salary and allowances since December 2023 while sitting at home.

BITTER PILL



For almost all of his two decades as CM, **Nitish Kumar** has let allies handle the tricky health portfolio. But as he readies his exit, he wrote a final prescription on April 11—a sweeping ban on private practice by government doctors in Bihar. It's a classic Nitish twist, a legacy note signed just before leaving the ward.

Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Avishek G. Dastidar, Prasad Nichenametla and Amitabh Srivastava

ECO WATCH

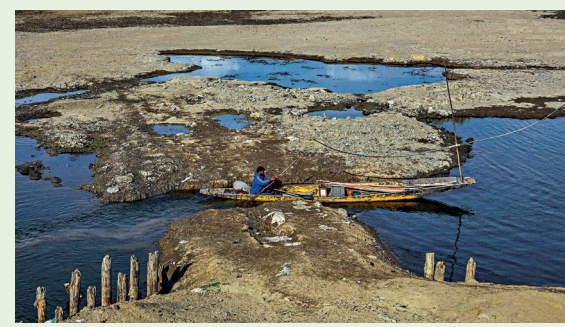
J&K LAKES ALARMING DECLINE

By **Jumana Shah**

That Jammu and Kashmir was "Paradise on Earth" was decreed centuries ago. But now it's come to light that much of what made it heaven has ebbed away: 70 per cent of J&K's natural lakes have either dried up or shrunk in size since 1967, says a damning audit by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India. The report, 'Conservation and Management of Lakes in J&K for the period ended March 2022', was tabled in the assembly in March.

Of J&K's 697 natural lakes—with a combined area of 28,990 hectares—315 have disappeared and 203 have shrunk. Among the latter, 63 lakes have lost over half their area, putting them also at high risk of extinction. The causes are both human and environmental—changes in land use within lake bodies and their catchment areas, compounded by deforestation, climate change and altered catchment dynamics. The 2014 floods also accelerated the degradation.

The audit puts the blame squarely on the administration. The management of J&K's lakes is fragmented across five departments—forest, revenue, agriculture, housing and urban development, and tourism. A draft bill to establish a dedicated regulatory authority for lake conservation was prepared in April 2000, but, due to 'the indifferent approach of the government...', it has not been enacted yet.



AFP

Conservation efforts, where they exist, are woeful in scope. Indeed, the government has programmes for only six lakes now—Dal, Wular, Hokersar, Manasbal, Surinsar and Mansar. ■